

Two Towns Want a New Bridge for Bikes and Walkers

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-07 3 min read

The Market Street Bridge crosses the Ohio River. It connects Steubenville, Ohio, with Weirton, West Virginia. But the old steel bridge closed in late 2023. It is too **rusty** to fix.

The bridge was the only safe way for people walking or biking to cross the river. After it closed, some downtown shops got fewer visitors.

People want a new bridge for another reason, too. The river is a big gap in the Great American **Rail-Trail**. This trail turns old railroad routes into paths for bikes and walkers. It would stretch about 3,700 miles across the country. More than half of it is already built.

Leaders from both **political parties** support the new bridge. Steubenville's mayor is a **Republican**. Weirton's mayor is a **Democrat**. Both say it would help their towns.

Congress has given \$87 million so far. But the bridge will cost more. Leaders are asking for more money.

Word Treasure

rusty -- Covered in rust, the reddish crust that forms when iron or steel gets old and wet.

Rail-Trail -- A path for bikes and walkers built where old train tracks used to be.

political parties -- Groups of people who share ideas about how the government should work.

Republican -- A member of one of the two biggest political parties in the United States.

Democrat -- A member of one of the two biggest political parties in the United States.

Congress -- The part of the U.S. government that makes laws and decides how to spend money.

Background you need

Rail-trails are paths for walking and biking built where trains used to run.

The Ohio River separates Ohio and West Virginia, so people need bridges to cross it.

Building a big bridge costs a lot of money, so towns often ask the government for help.

Break it down

WHO: Mayors and leaders of Steubenville, Ohio, and Weirton, West Virginia

WHAT: They want a new bridge with a path for bikes and walkers

WHERE: Over the Ohio River between Steubenville and Weirton

WHY: The old bridge closed, and the river is a gap in a cross-country trail

Why it matters

A safe bridge helps families walk, bike and visit shops in their towns.

Test what you remember

1. What river does the Market Street Bridge cross?
 - ☐ (A) The Hudson River
 - ☐ (B) The Ohio River
 - ☐ (C) The Mississippi River
 - ☐ (D) The Colorado River
2. Why can't the old bridge be fixed?
 - ☐ (A) It is too short
 - ☐ (B) It is made of wood
 - ☐ (C) It is too rusty
 - ☐ (D) It is too new
3. Who used the bridge to cross safely?
 - ☐ (A) Only trucks
 - ☐ (B) Only boats
 - ☐ (C) People walking or biking
 - ☐ (D) Only trains
4. About how long would the Great American Rail-Trail be?
 - ☐ (A) 37 miles
 - ☐ (B) 37,000 miles
 - ☐ (C) 370 miles
 - ☐ (D) 3,700 miles
5. Which parties do the two mayors belong to?
 - ☐ (A) Both Democrat
 - ☐ (B) One Republican and one Democrat
 - ☐ (C) Both Republican
 - ☐ (D) Neither party
6. How much money has Congress given so far?
 - ☐ (A) Nothing
 - ☐ (B) \$3,700
 - ☐ (C) \$1 billion
 - ☐ (D) \$87 million

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Mayors of Steubenville and Weirton: Both support the new bridge and say it would help their towns.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):